
The Architecture of a Pause: Iced Tea and Existential Order on the Academic Periphery

An Ethnographic Study of "I Am Khorshed" through the lens of Hemingway's "A Clean, Well-Lighted Place"

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Introduction: The Refuge from "Nada"

In the narrative of Ernest Hemingway's *"A Clean, Well-Lighted Place,"* there is no character conflict; instead, one finds that contrast between nothingness (the "Nada," which is all and everything that this human condition afflicts) and being. It was a nothing that the older waiter had not been troubled by, as he now remembers it. It was nothing and a man was nothing either. To get through this, you are not going to need luxury but a place that is dispensing light, order, and dignity.

These spaces are known, in the work of sociologist Ray Oldenburg, as "Third Places." For a Dhaka-based student, the post-lecture void is filled with study fatigue, traffic's hullabaloo, and the relentless cry of the school. The iced tea stall, **"I Am Khorshed"**, is located very close to the periphery of the campus and is the required counter-measure. It is neither high-end nor low-end; it lacks the fanciness of a cafe yet avoids the squalor of a street stand. It is put at exactly the correct mid-point needed to project dignity and serves as a contemporary electric shield against the darkness.

The Physical Environment: A Clean, Well-Lighted Stall

The waiter who is older in Hemingway makes an important distinction between a "bodega" (where one stands to drink in an uncomfortable position) and a "clean place" (where one sits). He notes, *"Nor can you stand before a bar with dignity although that is all that is provided for these hours."* The beauty of the experience is in the setup.

That is exactly what makes "I Am Khorshed" distinctive from the surrounding clutter. Out into the road is slotted in-between the high rises and curdled wires (as seen in Figure 1), a bite

out of dense city flesh. The outside world is chaos, and the inside world tries to impose order.



(a) The wider street context.



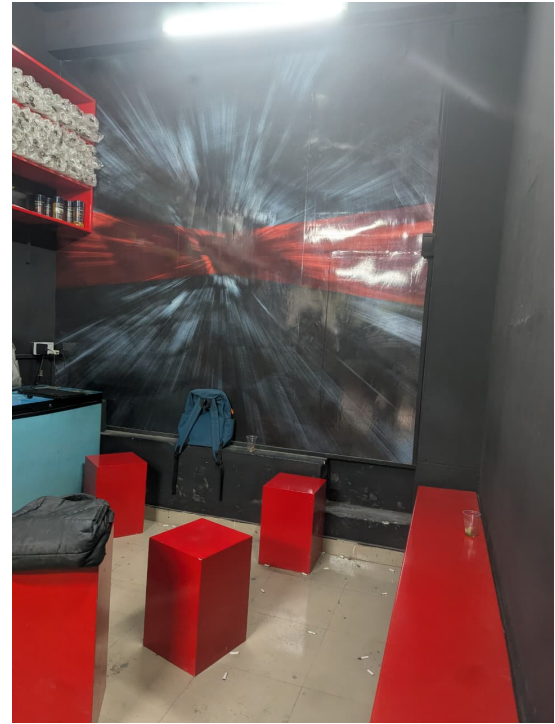
(b) Closer view of the surroundings.

Figure 1: **The Context.** The stall acts as a visual break in the vertical monotony of the academic periphery.

The bold "I AM KHORSHED" signboard (Figure 2a) is their fight for identity against the disappearing nature of a city. Inside, lines of "warp speed" cover the walls. This creates a visual paradox: the art gives the appearance of speed, like that with which the Young Waiter wants to get home; however, one of the functions of the red stools is stillness. It provides the purity the elder waiter longed for, which is not being in contact with the street dirt.



(a) The bold exterior branding.



(b) Interior abstract mural.

Figure 2: **Visual Identity.** The red and black aesthetic creates a contained environment, separating the 'inside' from the 'outside'.

Atmosphere and Sensory Observations: The Temperature of Solace

Hemingway uses extreme senses in his story of juxtaposition of the "shadows of the leaves" and the "electric light." The contrast of senses at "I Am Khorshed" is thermal.

Dhaka is loud, humid, and hot—a sensory "Nada." The shop offers a counter-sensory experience: the sound of ice and things getting cold on the pitcher (Figure 3). The silence is not a low decibel pitch, but it is a low pitch in terms of spirit. The iced tea making-shaking, pouring, stirring has a rhythm that drowns out the din of the streets. The ice box with the beach scene is a small vision of escape like the brandy for the deaf old man: a tiny, material balm to an indifferent world.



Figure 3: **The Source of Solace.** The blue ice box and pitcher symbolize the cooling relief central to the experience of this Third Place.

Activities and The Keeper of the Place

The central figure in Hemingway's story is the Old Waiter, who understands that he must keep the café open because "*I am of those who like to stay late at the café.*" He serves with a grave dignity, contrasting with the Young Waiter's impatience.

We watch the modern-day equivalent: the waiter at "I Am Khorshed" (Figure 4). He is unsmiling and focused. He is not carrying on mere empty prattle; like a druggist, he makes the tea. That gravity is a positive indication of the customer's existence. This server is giving the students time to stay just as the Old Waiter refused to hurry the Old Man (protecting him from the desire of the Young Waiter who wanted to close down). What is happening here isn't just "drinking tea"; it is *pausing*. The students walk in, they drop their heavy bags (burdens), and sit.



Figure 4: **The Server.** His serious demeanor anchors the space. He is the guardian of the 'clean, well-lighted' environment.

Community and Social Dynamics

The stall features two classes of people, which is similar to the dichotomy of the two waiters of the text.

1. **The "Young Waiter" Types:** Clusters of noisy students who purchase tea and take their leave. As the Old Waiter says to his colleague, *"You have youth, confidence, and a job."* These students have places to be, assignments to submit, and confidence in the future.
2. **The "Old Waiter/Old Man" Types:** The drinkers or silent couples that sit upon the red stools. They are not in a hurry. They are there because, as the story suggests, they need *"a light for the night."*

The stall is the means of a community of mutual silence of this second category. We sit at

the same table, having the same amber beverage, and all we need is a break after the academic round.

Personal Connection: Insomnia and Tea

"Each night I am reluctant to close up because there may be someone who needs the café," the Old Waiter muses.

I choose this place because more often than not, I am the "one in need of the café." There is nothing exciting about coming back to an empty room after you spent all day learning how to code and going to class. As shown in Figure 5, I am sitting on the stool, which is very low, and I am facing the other way from where the camera is: I am talking to the world through a drink in my mouth. The iced tea isn't just a drink, it is an excuse to be seated and not yet asking the question. It offers a resolution to the metaphorical blindness of the academic mind—that we can never make the noise of those demands go away.



Figure 5: **Self Portrait.** A moment of introspection. The iced tea serves as a medium for relaxation, allowing me to disconnect from the institutional environment just down the road.

Symbolic Connections: Light Against the Dark

The most profound connection to the text is the lighting. The Old Waiter explicitly states, *"It is the light of course but it is necessary that the place be clean and pleasant."*

During the day the stall is banal. However, at night (Figure 6), the neon tube linings highlight the stall and outline it in a fiery way against the dark alley. This light is existential. It is the point of demarcation between the "Third Place" (safety, tea, order) and the street (chaos, darkness, nada). The shadows are absorbed by the black walls and the red light insists on life. It is the **"well-lighted place"** that keeps the nothingness at bay.



Figure 6: **Electric Refuge.** At night, the neon lights fulfill Hemingway’s requirement for a “well-lighted place,” pushing back the shadows.

Reflections on Change and Imagination

In case “I Am Khorshed” were rewritten as a place setting, it would serve as the setting of a debate about ambition and contentment in modern times. The title of the mural, “Warp Speed,” implies the need to rush—the aspiration of the university—but it is the stall which sells the slowing down.

Should this place be closed down early, as the young waiter desired, the students must either be pushed back into the “nada” of the dark streets or the solitude of their rooms. The stall makes the raw material of water, sugar, and tea leaves into a provisional remedy for contemporary loneliness. It proves that what Hemingway saw is true: we do not simply need a drink, we need

a clean, well-lit place to drink it.

References

1. Hemingway, Ernest. "A Clean, Well-Lighted Place." *Winner Take Nothing*, Charles Scribner's Sons, 1933.
2. Oldenburg, Ray. *The Great Good Place: Cafés, Coffee Shops, Bookstores, Bars, Hair Salons, and Other Hangouts at the Heart of a Community*. Paragon House, 1989.